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123 Deal: The Big Turnabout

Following India's Peaceful Nuclear Explosion (PNE) in May 1974, the United States initiated a move to punish India by creating a multilateral export control regime on the pretext that nuclear technology transfers for peaceful purposes could be misused by non-nuclear weapon states for their nuclear weapons programmes. [1] It was called the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG). Two sets of guidelines were established for nuclear exports and nuclear-related exports, and the membership was systematically expanded to rope in any Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) signatory who had the relevant technologies. Although it was never stated that India was the target, an important intent was to cripple India's nuclear weapons research and development. China was not a founder-member of the NSG. In fact, in 1975, China was not a signatory to the NPT either.

India's decision to test in May 1998 was influenced by many factors and is not the subject of this book. The tests demonstrated that while the US-led nuclear sanctions may have